Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C N Annadurai was to participate in a discussion with Sarabhai and a few scientists and officials over the identification of a site from a shortlist proposed by Vikram Sarabhai. Annadurai could not attend the meeting because of severe shoulder pain, and he deputed Mathiyazhagan, one of his ministers, for the meeting. Sarabhai was kept waiting, and after sometime, the minister was 'brought' to the meeting—with a few holding him from falling. The politician irritated Sarabhai no end with his impossible demands and incoherence. Much before the meeting got over, Sarabhai had decided Tamil Nadu is not the place to be.

Just then Andhra Pradesh made an offer virtually nobody could refuse. Take the 26,000 acre Sriharikota island, he told Sarabhai. With India's rocket launch pad coming up there, the Andhra Pradesh government must have realised that the sparsely inhabited place may see some development. There were a few fishing hamlets along the Bay of Bengal on one side of the island, which had a lagoon (Pulicat Lake) on the other side. Villagers on the inland side were also cooperative. ISRO had to lay a road across the lagoon to reach the island where now stands two launch pads and a few other facilities. Today, a rocket lifting off, spewing fire and smoke reflected on the Pulicat Lake, where migratory flamingoes come to roost is quite a sight.

Sriharikota, however, has one disadvantage. It is a cyclone-prone region. During October-November, when the northeast monsoon lashes the Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu coast, planning a rocket launch is a precarious exercise. I have always felt the need for a launch pad outside Sriharikota, and this I tried hard while surveying land for the Mahendragiri project.

After Nagercoil was finalised, during one of my rounds of the district, I strayed into a couple of coastal hamlets called Panankulam and Chenankulam. The fishing hamlets together had not more than twenty-five families and a church. The sea was relatively shallow along a 10 km stretch of this place called Irukkanthurai, and hence it was not a favourite patch for